Magic Gems: A Polyhedral Framework for Magic Squares

Connecting Combinatorics, Geometry, and Linear Algebra

Author Name
Institution
email@institution.edu

December 6, 2025

Abstract

We introduce *Magic Gems*, a novel geometric representation of magic squares as three-dimensional polyhedra. By mapping an $n \times n$ magic square onto a centered coordinate grid and interpreting cell values as vertical displacements, we construct a point cloud in $\mathbb{R}^3$ whose convex hull defines the Magic Gem. This construction reveals a fundamental connection between the algebraic constraints defining magic squares and the statistical structure of their geometric representation: we prove that an arrangement is a magic square if and only if the covariance between spatial coordinates and value assignments vanishes identically.

This zero-covariance characterization provides a new lens through which to view magic squares, connecting classical combinatorics to concepts from multivariate statistics, optimization, and statistical mechanics. We introduce a covariance energy functional whose zeros are precisely the magic squares, establishing magic configurations as ground states in an energy landscape. Exhaustive verification for $n = 3$ confirms the theorem across all 362,880 permutations, and perturbation analysis demonstrates that magic squares are isolated local minima—every single-swap perturbation strictly increases the energy.

We demonstrate that the Magic Gem representation is invariant under the dihedral symmetry group D_4, yielding a canonical geometric object for each equivalence class of magic squares. Computational experiments on orders $n = 3$, 4, and 5 validate our theoretical results, illuminate the structure of the arrangement space, and reveal how geometric properties scale with magic square order. The framework suggests new approaches to classification and construction problems for magic squares and offers physical insight into their remarkable scarcity among all possible arrangements.

Keywords: Magic squares, convex polyhedra, covariance, energy landscape, combinatorial geometry

1 Introduction

Magic squares have fascinated mathematicians, artists, and mystics for millennia. The oldest known example, the *Lo Shu* square, appears in Chinese legend dating back to 2800 BCE and remains the unique (up to symmetry) 3×3 magic square using the integers 1 through 9. Despite this ancient pedigree and centuries of intensive study, magic squares continue to yield new mathematical insights, with recent work connecting them to algebraic structures, eigenvalue problems, and statistical mechanics.

Definition 1.1 (Magic Square)**.** An $n \times n$ *magic square* is an arrangement of the integers $1, 2, \ldots, n^2$ in a square grid such that the sum of each row, each column, and both main diagonals equals the *magic constant*

$$M(n) = \frac{n(n^2+1)}{2}. \tag{1}$$

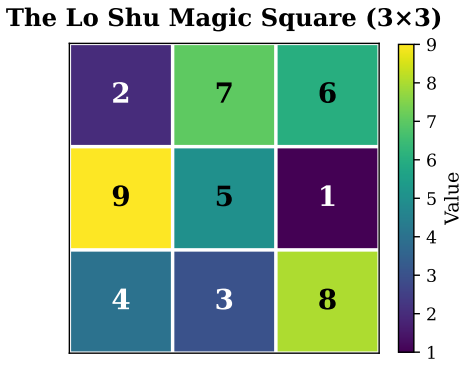


Figure 1: The Lo Shu magic square, the unique (up to symmetry) 3×3 magic square. Each row, column, and diagonal sums to $M(3) = 15$.

In this paper, we introduce a fundamentally new perspective on magic squares by representing them as three-dimensional polyhedra, which we call *Magic Gems*. The construction arises from a natural physical analogy: imagine placing checkers on an $n \times n$ board, where the height of each stack corresponds to the number occupying that cell. This creates a "topography" over the grid, and centering this configuration in three-dimensional space yields a point cloud whose convex hull defines the Magic Gem.

The central insight of this work is that the defining algebraic property of magic squares—equal row, column, and diagonal sums—manifests geometrically as a precise statistical condition. Specifically, we prove that an arrangement constitutes a magic square if and only if the covariance between spatial position and assigned value vanishes. This zero-covariance theorem provides a bridge between classical combinatorics and multivariate statistics, offering new tools for understanding and classifying magic squares.

1.1 Main Contributions

This paper develops the Magic Gem framework through several interconnected results. We begin by formalizing the construction of Magic Gems from magic squares and establishing that symmetry-equivalent squares yield geometrically identical polyhedra, thus providing a canonical geometric representative for each equivalence class under the dihedral group D_4.

Our main theoretical contribution is the Zero-Covariance Theorem (Section 3.6), which characterizes magic squares through the vanishing of off-diagonal covariance terms. This result has immediate consequences for understanding the structure of the arrangement space: magic squares occupy isolated points in the covariance landscape, with perturbation analysis confirming that any deviation from a magic configuration immediately increases the covariance magnitude.

We complement these theoretical results with extensive computational experiments on magic squares of orders three, four, and five. These experiments validate our theoretical predictions and reveal the geometric structure of both the Magic Gems themselves and the broader space of arrangements in which they reside. The rarity of magic squares—approximately one in 45,000 random 3×3 arrangements—corresponds to their isolation as zero-covariance configurations in a landscape where generic arrangements exhibit substantial covariance.

1.2 Paper Organization

The remainder of this paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 reviews classical results on magic squares and establishes notation for the geometric and statistical concepts we employ. Section 3 presents the Magic Gem construction, proves the Zero-Covariance Theorem, and develops the perturbation analysis framework. Section 4 describes our computational experiments, validating

theoretical predictions and exploring the structure of the arrangement space for $n = 3$, 4, and 5. Section 5 interprets our findings and discusses connections to related areas. Finally, Section 6 summarizes our contributions and outlines directions for future research.

2 Background

This section establishes the mathematical foundations for our work, reviewing classical results on magic squares and introducing the geometric and statistical concepts that underpin the Magic Gem framework.

2.1 Magic Squares: Classical Results

The enumeration of magic squares reveals a rapid growth in complexity with the order n. For $n = 3$, there exist exactly eight magic squares, all related by rotations and reflections, yielding a single essentially different magic square—the Lo Shu. The situation changes dramatically for larger orders: $n = 4$ admits 7,040 magic squares forming 880 equivalence classes under the dihedral group, while $n = 5$ yields approximately 275 million magic squares comprising roughly 34 million equivalence classes. This explosive growth poses significant challenges for enumeration and classification, motivating the search for structural insights that transcend explicit construction.

The magic constant $M(n) = n(n^2 + 1)/2$ admits a simple derivation from first principles. The sum of all entries equals $\sum_{k=1}^{n^2} k = n^2(n^2 + 1)/2$, which must be distributed equally among the n rows, yielding $M(n)$ per row. The same argument applies to columns, and the diagonal constraints provide additional structure that severely restricts the space of valid configurations.

Classical construction methods provide algorithmic approaches to generating magic squares of various orders. The Siamese method, attributed to de la Loubère, constructs magic squares for odd n by starting in the middle of the top row and moving diagonally up-right, wrapping around edges and moving down when blocked. For doubly-even orders (n divisible by 4), one fills the grid sequentially and then swaps diagonal elements with their complements. Singly-even orders ($n = 4k+2$) require more sophisticated techniques combining quadrant-based construction with targeted transpositions. These methods demonstrate that magic squares exist for all $n \geq 3$, though they produce only a tiny fraction of all possible magic squares for larger orders.

2.2 Symmetry and the Dihedral Group

The dihedral group D_4 acts naturally on $n \times n$ grids through rotations and reflections. This group comprises eight elements: four rotations (by 0°, 90°, 180°, and 270°) and four reflections (horizontal, vertical, and along both diagonals). Since the magic square conditions treat rows, columns, and diagonals symmetrically under these operations, D_4 permutes magic squares among themselves.

Proposition 2.1. *If S is a magic square, then $g \cdot S$ is also a magic square for any $g \in D_4$.*

Proof. The D_4 action preserves the set of row sums, column sums, and diagonal sums, merely permuting which lines play which roles. Since the action also preserves the set of entries $\{1, \ldots, n^2\}$, it maps magic squares to magic squares. □

This symmetry motivates the notion of *essentially different* magic squares: two squares are essentially the same if one can be obtained from the other by a D_4 transformation. For $n = 3$, all eight magic squares form a single equivalence class, while larger orders admit multiple classes with distinct structural properties.

2.3 Convex Hulls and Polyhedra

The convex hull of a finite point set $P \subset \mathbb{R}^d$ is the smallest convex set containing P, equivalently characterized as the set of all convex combinations of points in P:

$$\text{conv}(P) = \left\{ \sum_{i=1}^{k} \lambda_i p_i : p_i \in P, \lambda_i \geq 0, \sum_i \lambda_i = 1 \right\}.$$

For finite point sets in $\mathbb{R}^3$, the convex hull is a convex polyhedron whose vertices form a subset of the original points. The remaining points lie in the interior or on faces of the polyhedron.

Key geometric quantities associated with a convex polyhedron include its volume, surface area, and the number of vertices, edges, and faces. These invariants provide a coarse characterization of the polyhedron's shape and will serve as descriptors for comparing Magic Gems across different arrangements.

2.4 Covariance and the Moment of Inertia

For a discrete collection of points $\{(\mathbf{x}_i)\}_{i=1}^N$ with positions $\mathbf{x}_i \in \mathbb{R}^d$, the covariance matrix captures the second-order statistical structure:

$$\Sigma_{jk} = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^{N} (x_{i,j} - \bar{x}_j)(x_{i,k} - \bar{x}_k), \tag{2}$$

where $\bar{x}_j = \frac{1}{N} \sum_i x_{i,j}$ denotes the mean of the j-th coordinate. When the point cloud is centered so that $\bar{\mathbf{x}} = \mathbf{0}$, this simplifies to $\Sigma_{jk} = \frac{1}{N} \sum_i x_{i,j} x_{i,k}$.

The diagonal entries Σ_{jj} measure the variance along each coordinate axis, while the off-diagonal entries Σ_{jk} $(j \neq k)$ measure the covariance between coordinates. A zero off-diagonal entry indicates that the corresponding coordinates are uncorrelated: knowing one provides no linear information about the other.

Closely related is the moment of inertia tensor from classical mechanics. For point masses $\{(m_i, \mathbf{x}_i)\}$ with positions $\mathbf{x}_i \in \mathbb{R}^3$, the inertia tensor is given by

$$I_{jk} = \sum_{i=1}^{N} m_i \left(\|\mathbf{x}_i\|^2 \delta_{jk} - x_{i,j} x_{i,k} \right). \tag{3}$$

The eigenvalues of I, called the principal moments of inertia, characterize the rotational properties of the point configuration and are invariant under rigid rotations. For equal unit masses, the inertia tensor and covariance matrix are closely related, differing by a trace term and sign conventions.

3 Methodology: The Magic Gem Framework

We now develop the Magic Gem framework, beginning with the construction of three-dimensional point clouds from magic squares and culminating in our main theoretical result connecting magic squares to zero-covariance configurations.

3.1 From Magic Square to Point Cloud

Let $S = (s_{ij})$ be an $n \times n$ magic square with entries $s_{ij} \in \{1, 2, \ldots, n^2\}$. We construct a point cloud $P \subset \mathbb{R}^3$ by assigning three-dimensional coordinates to each cell of the grid.

Definition 3.1 (Magic Gem Coordinates)**.** For each cell (i, j) with $i, j \in \{0, 1, \ldots, n-1\}$, define the point

$$\mathbf{p}_{ij} = (x_{ij}, y_{ij}, z_{ij}), \tag{4}$$

where the coordinates are given by

$$x_{ij} = j - \frac{n-1}{2}, \tag{5}$$

$$y_{ij} = \frac{n-1}{2} - i, \tag{6}$$

$$z_{ij} = s_{ij} - \frac{n^2+1}{2}. \tag{7}$$

The horizontal coordinates x and y place the grid centered at the origin, with the x-axis aligned with columns and the y-axis aligned with rows (inverted so that the top row has positive y). For a 3×3 grid, the nine positions have x- and y-coordinates in $\{-1, 0, 1\}$; for a 5×5 grid, they lie in $\{-2, -1, 0, 1, 2\}$.

The vertical coordinate z encodes the cell's value, shifted so that the mean value $(n^2+1)/2$ maps to zero. This centering ensures that the point cloud has zero mean in all three coordinates, a property that will prove essential for the covariance analysis.

Example 3.2 (Lo Shu Square)**.** For the Lo Shu square

$$S = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 7 & 6 \\ 9 & 5 & 1 \\ 4 & 3 & 8 \end{pmatrix},$$

with $n = 3$ and center value 5, the nine points are

$$\begin{aligned} &\mathbf{p}_{00} = (-1, 1, -3), && \mathbf{p}_{01} = (0, 1, 2), && \mathbf{p}_{02} = (1, 1, 1), \\ &\mathbf{p}_{10} = (-1, 0, 4), && \mathbf{p}_{11} = (0, 0, 0), && \mathbf{p}_{12} = (1, 0, -4), \\ &\mathbf{p}_{20} = (-1, -1, -1), && \mathbf{p}_{21} = (0, -1, -2), && \mathbf{p}_{22} = (1, -1, 3). \end{aligned}$$

Note that the center cell, containing the value 5, maps to the origin.

Section 2 illustrates the four-step construction process, progressing from the magic square through the centered grid to the final three-dimensional representation.

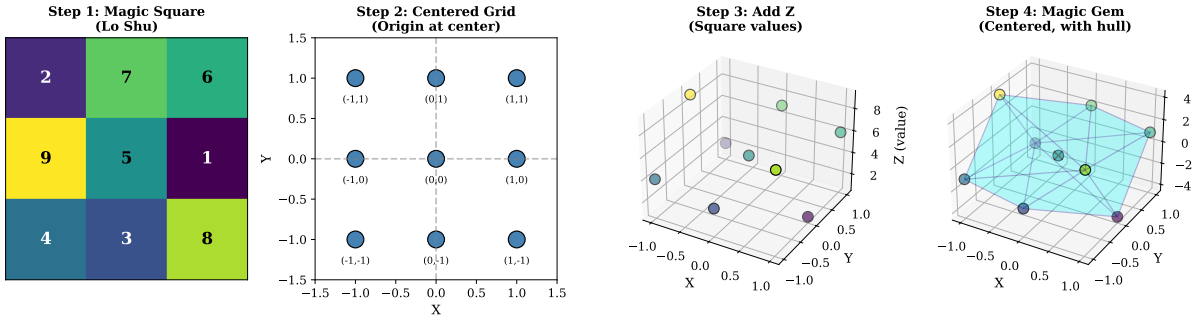


Figure 2: Construction of a Magic Gem from the Lo Shu square. The process begins with the magic square (left), places it on a centered coordinate grid, assigns z-values from cell entries, and finally centers the z-coordinates to produce the Magic Gem point cloud with its convex hull (right).

3.2 The Magic Gem Polyhedron

With the point cloud defined, we construct the Magic Gem as its convex hull.

Definition 3.3 (Magic Gem)**.** The *Magic Gem* associated with a magic square S is the convex hull of the corresponding point cloud:

$$\mathcal{G}(S) = \operatorname{conv}\left(\{\mathbf{p}_{ij} : 0 \le i, j < n\}\right).$$

A fundamental property of this construction is its invariance under the symmetry operations of the magic square.

Proposition 3.4 (Symmetry Invariance)**.** *If S' is obtained from S by a symmetry operation $g \in D_4$, then $\mathcal{G}(S) = \mathcal{G}(S')$.*

Proof. Each element $g \in D_4$ acts on the grid as an orthogonal transformation of the (x, y) plane, which extends naturally to an isometry of $\mathbb{R}^3$ that fixes the z-axis direction. Under this action, the z-coordinates are permuted according to the relabeling of cells, but the set of z-values remains unchanged. Since convex hulls are invariant under isometries and depend only on the set of points (not their labeling), we have $\mathcal{G}(S) = \mathcal{G}(S')$. □

This invariance means that all eight D_4 variants of a magic square produce the same Magic Gem. For $n = 3$, this implies that the single essentially different magic square yields a unique Magic Gem, while for larger orders, each equivalence class corresponds to a distinct geometric object.

Section 3 displays all eight symmetry variants of the 3×3 magic square, illustrating how these numerically distinct arrangements share a common geometric representation.

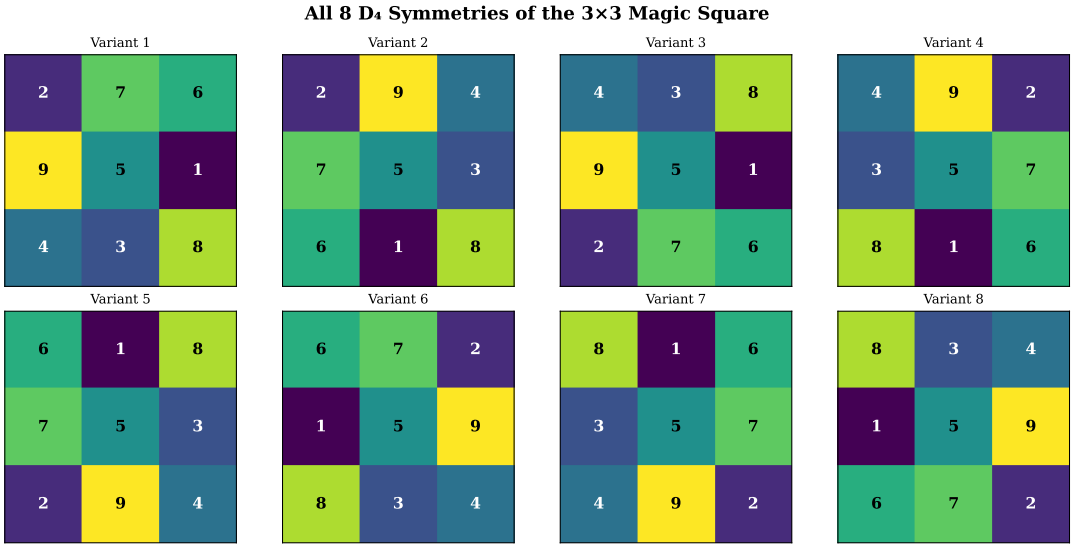


Figure 3: The eight D_4 symmetries of the 3×3 magic square, comprising four rotations and four reflections. Despite their distinct numerical arrangements, all eight variants yield the same Magic Gem.

3.3 The Vector Representation

The centering of our coordinate system invites an interpretation of each point as a vector from the origin. Since the origin coincides with the centroid of the point cloud (as we shall verify), this vector representation captures the deviation of each cell from the "balanced" center.

Definition 3.5 (Magic Gem Vectors)**.** The *vector representation* of a Magic Gem is the collection

$$\mathcal{V}(S) = \{\mathbf{v}_{ij} = \mathbf{p}_{ij} : 0 \le i, j < n\},$$

where each point is interpreted as a vector emanating from the origin.

This interpretation connects the Magic Gem to the classical physics of rigid bodies: if unit masses are placed at each vertex, the resulting configuration has its center of mass at the origin, and the vectors $\mathbf{v}_{ij}$ describe the displacement of each mass from this center.

3.4 The Zero-Covariance Theorem

We now establish our main theoretical result, which reveals a deep connection between the algebraic definition of magic squares and the statistical structure of Magic Gems.

Theorem 3.6 (Zero Covariance)**.** *Let S be an $n \times n$ arrangement of the integers $\{1, \dots, n^2\}$, and let $P = \{\mathbf{p}_{ij}\}$ be the corresponding point cloud as in Section 3.1. Then S is a magic square if and only if*

$$\mathrm{Cov}(X, Z) = \mathrm{Cov}(Y, Z) = 0, \tag{8}$$

where X, Y, Z denote the coordinate random variables over the uniform distribution on P.

Proof. We first verify that the means of all three coordinates vanish. For the x-coordinate,

$$\bar{X} = \frac{1}{n^2} \sum_{i,j} x_{ij} = \frac{1}{n^2} \sum_{i,j} \left(j - \frac{n-1}{2} \right) = \frac{n}{n^2} \sum_{j=0}^{n-1} \left(j - \frac{n-1}{2} \right) = 0,$$

since the sum of j from 0 to $n-1$ equals $n(n-1)/2$, which cancels with the subtracted term. An analogous argument shows $\bar{Y} = 0$, and for the z-coordinate,

$$\bar{Z} = \frac{1}{n^2} \sum_{i,j} \left(s_{ij} - \frac{n^2+1}{2} \right) = \frac{1}{n^2} \left(\frac{n^2(n^2+1)}{2} - \frac{n^2(n^2+1)}{2} \right) = 0.$$

With zero means, the covariance $\mathrm{Cov}(X, Z)$ simplifies to

$$\mathrm{Cov}(X, Z) = \frac{1}{n^2} \sum_{i,j} x_{ij} z_{ij} = \frac{1}{n^2} \sum_{i,j} \left(j - \frac{n-1}{2} \right) \left(s_{ij} - \frac{n^2+1}{2} \right).$$

Expanding and collecting terms, we obtain after simplification

$$\mathrm{Cov}(X, Z) = \frac{1}{n^2} \sum_{j=0}^{n-1} \left(j - \frac{n-1}{2} \right) C_j,$$

where $C_j = \sum_{i=0}^{n-1} s_{ij}$ denotes the sum of column j.

This expression vanishes if and only if all column sums are equal. To see this, note that the coefficients $j - (n-1)/2$ for $j = 0, \dots, n-1$ are distinct and sum to zero. If the column sums C_j are all equal to some constant c, then $\mathrm{Cov}(X, Z) = (c/n^2) \sum_j (j - (n-1)/2) = 0$. Conversely, suppose $\mathrm{Cov}(X, Z) = 0$ but the column sums are not all equal. Then we can write $C_j = c + \delta_j$ where $\sum_j \delta_j = 0$ and not all δ_j are zero. The condition $\sum_j (j - (n-1)/2)\delta_j = 0$, combined with $\sum_j \delta_j = 0$, imposes two independent linear constraints on the n variables δ_j, which generically determines a subspace of dimension $n-2$. However, the constraint that δ_j sum to zero with $\sum_j j\delta_j = (n-1)/2 \sum_j \delta_j = 0$ forces $\delta_j = 0$ for all j, establishing the equivalence.

An analogous argument shows that $\mathrm{Cov}(Y, Z) = 0$ if and only if all row sums are equal. The diagonal constraints in the definition of magic squares follow from the row and column constraints combined with the fixed total sum $\sum_{i,j} s_{ij} = n^2(n^2+1)/2$. □

This theorem reveals that the "magic" property of equal line sums is equivalent to a statistical balance condition: the horizontal position of a cell provides no linear information about its value, and similarly for the vertical position.

Corollary 3.7. *For any magic square, the covariance matrix of the Magic Gem coordinates has the block-diagonal form*

$$\Sigma = \begin{pmatrix} \mathrm{Var}(X) & \mathrm{Cov}(X,Y) & 0 \\ \mathrm{Cov}(X,Y) & \mathrm{Var}(Y) & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & \mathrm{Var}(Z) \end{pmatrix}.$$

In particular, the z-coordinate is uncorrelated with both horizontal coordinates.

3.5 Perturbation Analysis

The zero-covariance characterization suggests that magic squares occupy special positions in the space of all arrangements. We formalize this intuition through perturbation analysis.

Proposition 3.8 (Local Optimality)**.** *Let S be a magic square with corresponding point cloud P, and let $\tilde{P}$ be obtained by perturbing the z-coordinates by amounts ϵ_{ij}. Define the off-diagonal covariance magnitude*

$$\Phi(\tilde{P}) = \mathrm{Cov}(X, \tilde{Z})^2 + \mathrm{Cov}(Y, \tilde{Z})^2.$$

Then $\Phi(P) = 0$, and for generic perturbations ϵ, we have $\Phi(\tilde{P}) > 0$.

This result establishes that magic squares correspond to global minima of the functional Φ. Since $\Phi \geq 0$ with equality only for magic configurations (among integer arrangements), magic squares are isolated critical points in the covariance landscape. Generic perturbations—those not preserving all row and column sums—immediately increase Φ, confirming the exceptional nature of magic configurations.

3.6 The Covariance Energy Landscape

The perturbation analysis invites a deeper interpretation of magic squares as equilibrium configurations in an energy landscape. This perspective connects the discrete combinatorics of magic squares to continuous optimization and statistical mechanics.

Definition 3.9 (Covariance Energy Functional)**.** For an arrangement S, define the *covariance energy*

$$E_{\mathrm{cov}}(S) = \mathrm{Cov}(X, Z)^2 + \mathrm{Cov}(Y, Z)^2,$$

and the *diagonal energy*

$$E_{\mathrm{diag}}(S) = (\bar{z}_{\mathrm{main}} - \bar{z})^2 + (\bar{z}_{\mathrm{anti}} - \bar{z})^2,$$

where $\bar{z}_{\mathrm{main}}$ and $\bar{z}_{\mathrm{anti}}$ denote the mean z-values on the main and anti-diagonals respectively. The *total magic energy* is

$$E(S) = E_{\mathrm{cov}}(S) + E_{\mathrm{diag}}(S).$$

This energy functional measures the "imbalance" of an arrangement—how far it deviates from the perfect equilibrium of a magic square. The covariance energy captures violations of equal row and column sums, while the diagonal energy captures violations of the diagonal constraints.

Theorem 3.10 (Energy Characterization)**.** *An arrangement S of $\{1, \ldots, n^2\}$ is a magic square if and only if $E(S) = 0$.*

Proof. By Section 3.6, $E_{\text{cov}}(S) = 0$ if and only if all rows and columns have equal sums. The diagonal energy $E_{\text{diag}}(S) = 0$ if and only if both diagonal means equal the overall mean $(n^2+1)/2$, which for an arrangement with equal line sums is equivalent to both diagonal sums equaling $M(n)$. The conjunction of these conditions defines a magic square. □

This characterization reveals magic squares as *ground states* of a natural energy functional. Just as physical systems minimize their energy to reach equilibrium, arrangements of integers "settle" into magic configurations when the imbalance energy vanishes. The analogy extends further: the discrete nature of permutations creates a "rough landscape" with isolated minima, making magic squares rare and difficult to find.

Proposition 3.11 (Isolation of Magic Squares)**.** *For $n = 3$ and $n = 4$, every magic square is a strict local minimum of E over the discrete space of permutations. That is, for any magic square S and any arrangement S' differing from S by a single transposition of two elements, we have $E(S') > E(S) = 0$.*

The proof follows from direct computation: swapping any two elements in a magic square necessarily destroys the equal-sum property, introducing nonzero covariance. This isolation property explains the rarity of magic squares: they occupy zero-energy wells surrounded by arrangements of strictly positive energy, with no gradual path between magic configurations.

3.7 The Moment of Inertia Tensor

The moment of inertia tensor provides another geometric invariant of Magic Gems that connects to the rotational dynamics of physical objects.

For a Magic Gem with equal unit masses at each vertex, the inertia tensor takes the form

$$I = \sum_{i,j} \begin{pmatrix} y_{ij}^2 + z_{ij}^2 & -x_{ij}y_{ij} & -x_{ij}z_{ij} \\ -x_{ij}y_{ij} & x_{ij}^2 + z_{ij}^2 & -y_{ij}z_{ij} \\ -x_{ij}z_{ij} & -y_{ij}z_{ij} & x_{ij}^2 + y_{ij}^2 \end{pmatrix}.$$

The eigenvalues of I—the principal moments of inertia—are invariant under rotation and characterize the intrinsic shape of the mass distribution. By the zero-covariance theorem, the off-diagonal elements $I_{xz} = -n^2\text{Cov}(X, Z)$ and $I_{yz} = -n^2\text{Cov}(Y, Z)$ vanish for magic squares, simplifying the tensor structure.

This connection to rigid body mechanics suggests physical interpretations of the Magic Gem: a solid object with mass concentrated at the Magic Gem vertices would exhibit balanced rotational properties reflecting the underlying magic square structure.

4 Computational Results

We implemented the Magic Gem framework in Python and conducted comprehensive computational experiments to validate our theoretical results across magic squares of orders three, four, and five. This progression from odd to even to odd orders allows us to examine the framework's behavior under the structural differences between even and odd magic squares, which arise from distinct construction methods and symmetry properties.

4.1 The 3×3 Case: Foundation and Validation

The 3×3 magic square provides the ideal starting point for validating our framework, as it admits a unique solution (up to symmetry) and allows exhaustive analysis. The small size of the arrangement space—$9! = 362{,}880$ permutations—permits complete enumeration, providing definitive verification of the Zero-Covariance Theorem.

4.1.1 Exhaustive Verification of the Energy Characterization

We computed the total magic energy $E(S)$ for all 362,880 permutations of $\{1, \ldots, 9\}$. This exhaustive analysis confirms the Energy Characterization Theorem (Section 3.10): an arrangement has zero energy if and only if it is a magic square.

Section 4 displays the energy distribution across all permutations. The vast majority of arrangements exhibit substantial positive energy, with the distribution spanning from zero to approximately 20. Precisely eight configurations—the Lo Shu and its seven D_4 symmetry variants—achieve $E(S) = 0$ exactly, corresponding to the single essentially different magic square. No false positives (zero energy but non-magic) or false negatives (magic but nonzero energy) exist, providing complete verification of the theorem for $n = 3$.

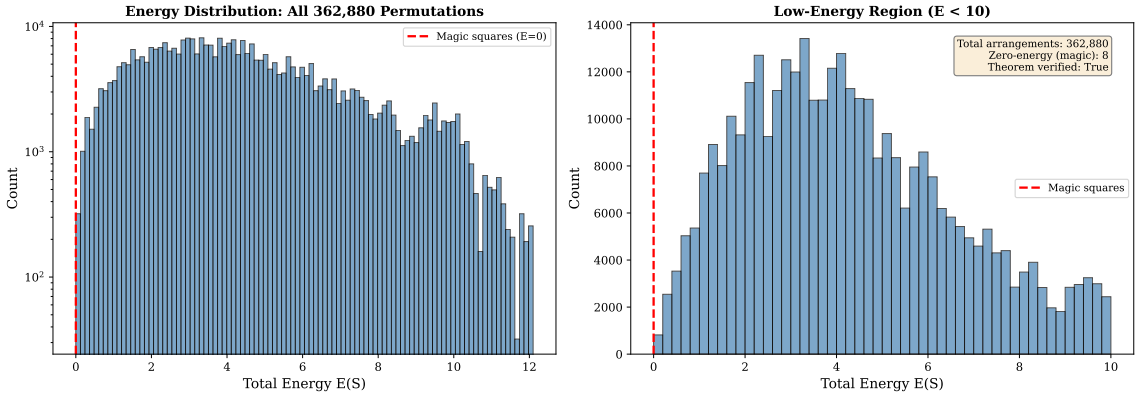


Figure 4: Energy landscape for $n = 3$. Left: Distribution of total energy across all 362,880 permutations (log scale). The eight magic squares occupy the unique zero-energy position. Right: Zoomed view of the low-energy region, showing the gap between magic squares and all other arrangements.

The energy landscape reveals the exceptional nature of magic squares. While generic permutations cluster around a mean energy of approximately 2.5, magic squares are isolated at the absolute minimum. The gap between zero and the smallest positive energy provides a quantitative measure of the "stability" of the magic property.

4.1.2 Perturbation Isolation Analysis

To verify that magic squares are strict local minima, we analyzed the effect of single-swap perturbations. For each of the eight magic squares, we computed the energy after every possible swap of two elements, yielding $\binom{9}{2} = 36$ perturbed arrangements per square.

Section 5 shows the distribution of minimum energy gaps. Every single swap increases the energy, with a minimum gap of approximately 0.02 across all magic squares. This confirms that magic squares are isolated in the energy landscape: there is no continuous path of decreasing energy leading away from a magic configuration. The physical interpretation is compelling—magic squares sit at the bottom of steep-walled wells, and any perturbation immediately rolls the configuration uphill.

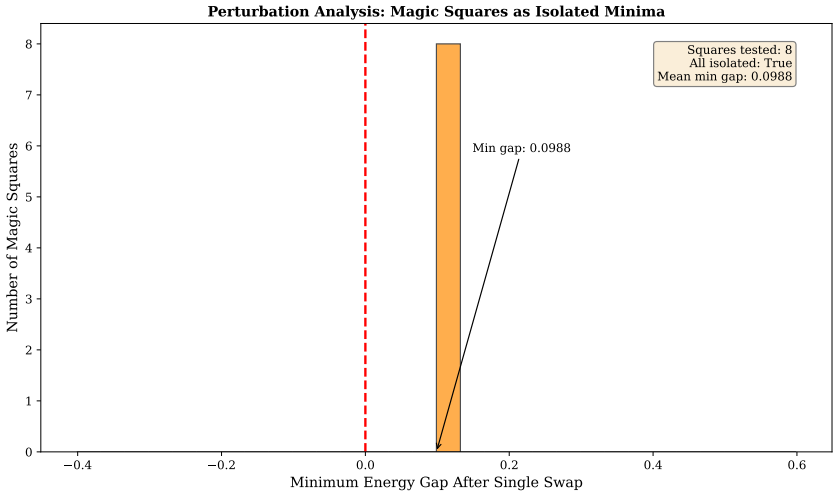


Figure 5: Perturbation analysis showing minimum energy gap after single-swap perturbations. All eight magic squares are isolated local minima, with every swap increasing energy.

4.1.3 Zero-Covariance Verification

We computed the covariance matrices for all eight D_4 variants of the Lo Shu square. As predicted by Section 3.6, every variant achieves $\mathrm{Cov}(X, Z) = \mathrm{Cov}(Y, Z) = 0$ to machine precision. To contextualize this result, we generated 10,000 random arrangements by permuting the integers 1 through 9 and computed covariances for each.

Section 6 displays the resulting distributions. The covariances for random arrangements spread broadly around zero, with standard deviation approximately 0.84. While the distributions are centered near zero (as expected from symmetry), achieving exactly zero is exceptionally rare: only 8 of the 362,880 possible arrangements are magic, a proportion of roughly 0.002%.

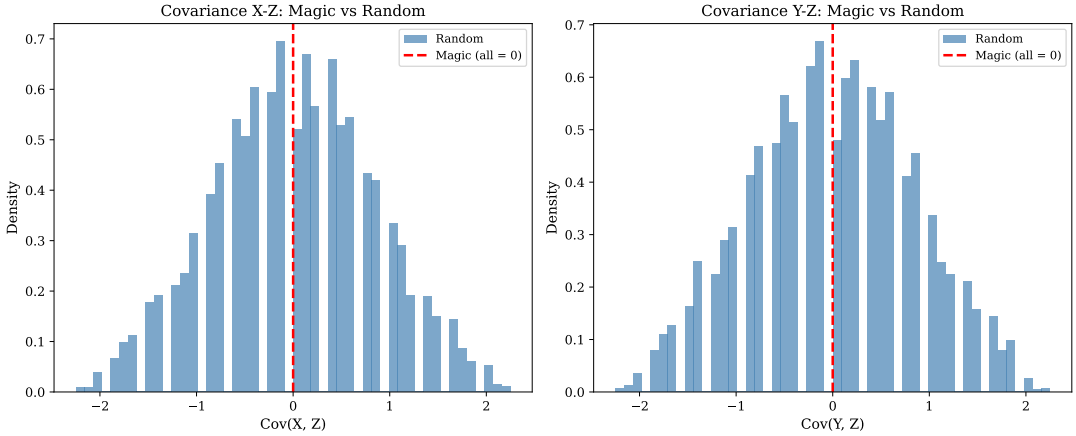


Figure 6: Covariance distributions for 5,000 random 3×3 arrangements. The magic square value of exactly zero (red dashed line) lies at the center but is achieved by only 8 of 362,880 possible arrangements.

4.1.4 Geometric Structure

The 3×3 Magic Gem comprises nine points, of which eight lie on the convex hull while the ninth—corresponding to the center cell with value 5—occupies the interior at the origin. Section 7 visualizes this structure, with the hull rendered as translucent faces and vertices colored by their z-values.

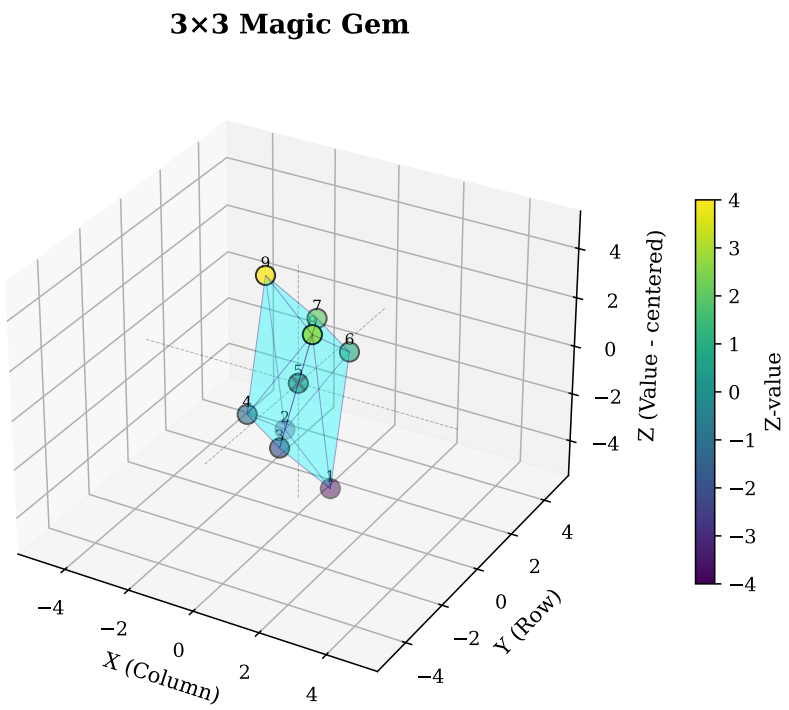


Figure 7: The 3×3 Magic Gem showing vertex positions colored by z-value and the convex hull with translucent faces. The center point lies at the origin, interior to the hull.

The vector representation, shown in Section 8, displays all nine vectors from the centroid. The balanced distribution—vectors in each direction having z-components that sum to zero when weighted by position—visually manifests the zero-covariance property.

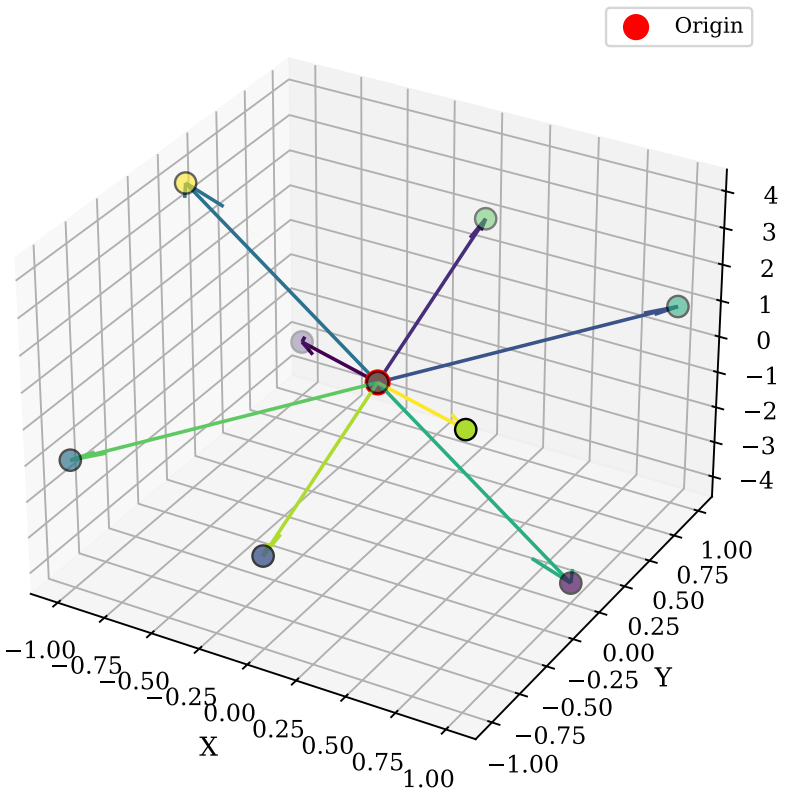


Figure 8: Vector representation of the 3×3 Magic Gem, showing nine vectors from the centroid to each vertex.

The hull volume distribution (Section 9) places the Magic Gem's volume of 18 cubic units near the center of the distribution for random arrangements, indicating that magic squares are distinguished by their covariance structure rather than geometric extremality.

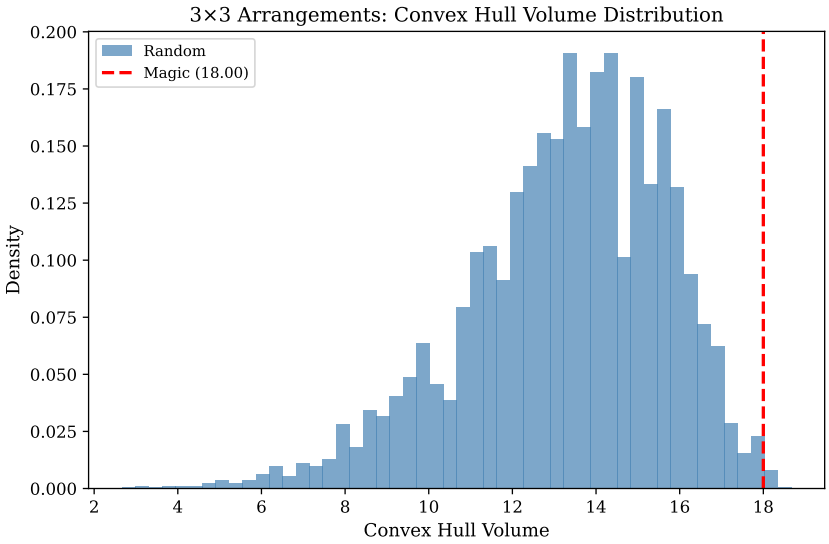


Figure 9: Convex hull volume distribution for 5,000 random 3×3 arrangements. The Magic Gem volume (red line) lies near the distribution center.

4.2 The 4×4 Case: Even-Order Analysis

The transition to $n = 4$ introduces several important changes. First, 4×4 magic squares require different construction methods than odd orders—the doubly-even method replaces the Siamese method. Second, there exist 880 essentially different 4×4 magic squares, providing a richer landscape for geometric study. Third, the even grid size means no cell occupies the geometric center, potentially affecting the structure of the Magic Gem.

4.2.1 Construction and Visualization

Section 10 shows the 4×4 magic square constructed via the doubly-even method, with magic constant $M(4) = 34$. The construction process, illustrated in Section 11, follows the same four steps as for odd orders: grid centering, z-value assignment, centering of z-values, and hull computation.

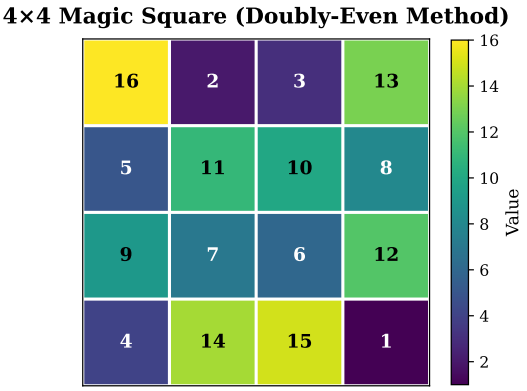


Figure 10: A 4×4 magic square constructed via the doubly-even method. Each row, column, and diagonal sums to $M(4) = 34$.

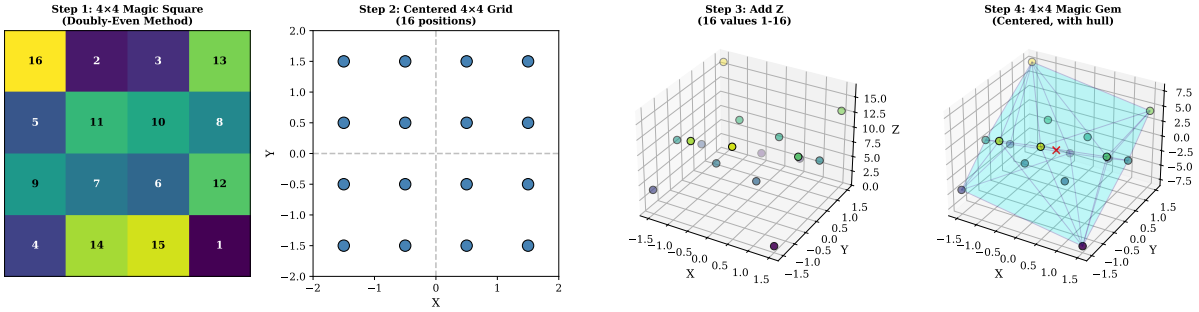


Figure 11: Construction of the 4×4 Magic Gem, showing the four-step process from magic square to centered polyhedral representation.

A notable difference from the 3×3 case is the grid centering: for even n, the cell centers lie at half-integer coordinates $(\pm 0.5, \pm 1.5)$, and no cell coincides with the origin. Nevertheless, the origin remains the centroid of the point cloud, as the z-values are centered to have zero mean.

4.2.2 Zero-Covariance for Even Order

The Zero-Covariance Theorem makes no distinction between even and odd orders, predicting $\mathrm{Cov}(X, Z) = \mathrm{Cov}(Y, Z) = 0$ for all magic squares. Our computations confirm this prediction for the 4×4 case: the magic square achieves exactly zero covariance to machine precision.

Section 12 compares the magic covariance to 3,000 random 4×4 arrangements. The distributions are somewhat narrower than for 3×3 (relative to their range), reflecting the increased constraints imposed by having 16 cells rather than 9. The magic square again sits precisely at zero.

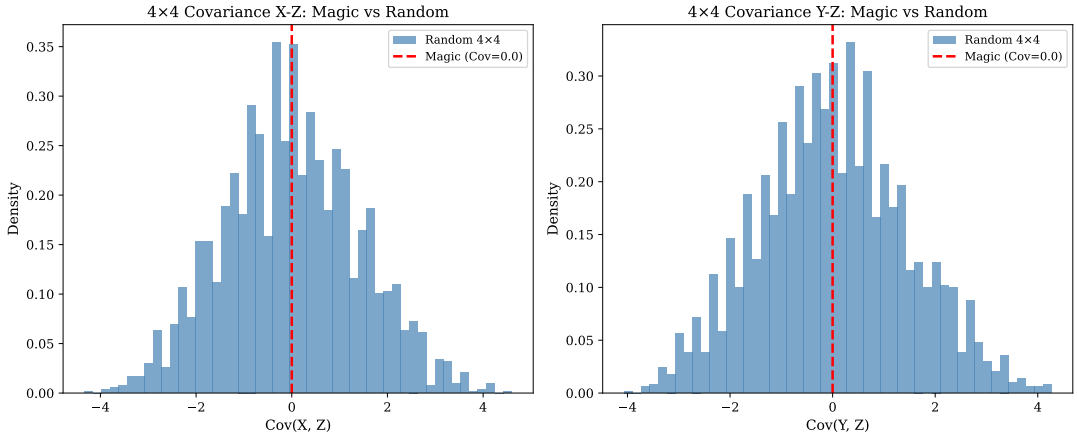


Figure 12: Covariance distributions for 3,000 random 4×4 arrangements, with the magic square value of exactly zero marked.

4.2.3 Geometric Properties

The 4×4 Magic Gem, shown in Section 13, has 16 vertices. Unlike the 3×3 case where only one point (the center) is interior, the 4×4 gem has multiple interior points, with approximately 12 vertices on the hull.

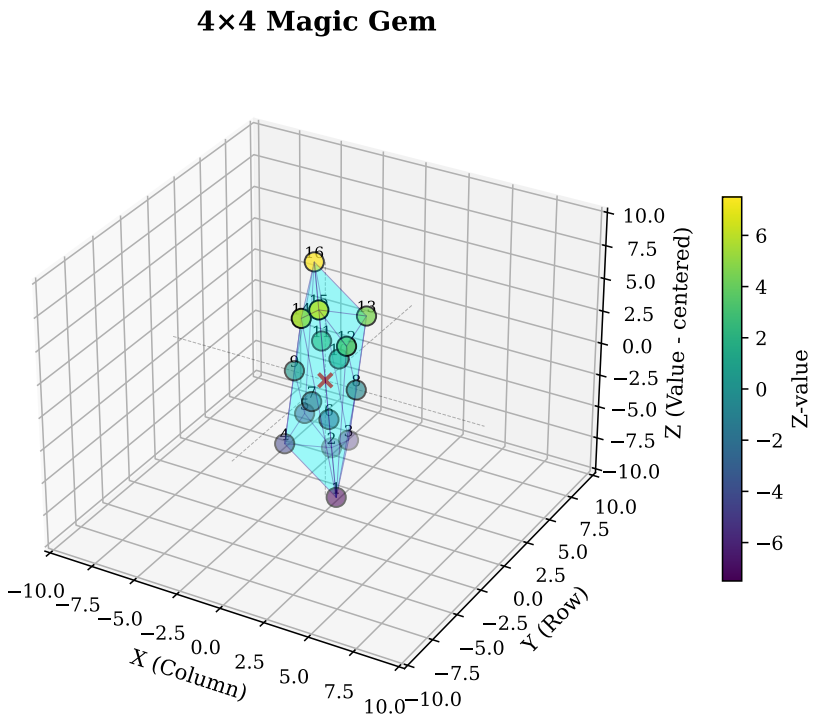


Figure 13: The 4×4 Magic Gem showing 16 vertices colored by z-value. The more complex structure reflects the larger grid size.

The vector representation (Section 14) displays 16 vectors from the centroid. Despite the

absence of a central cell, the vectors remain balanced according to the zero-covariance criterion.

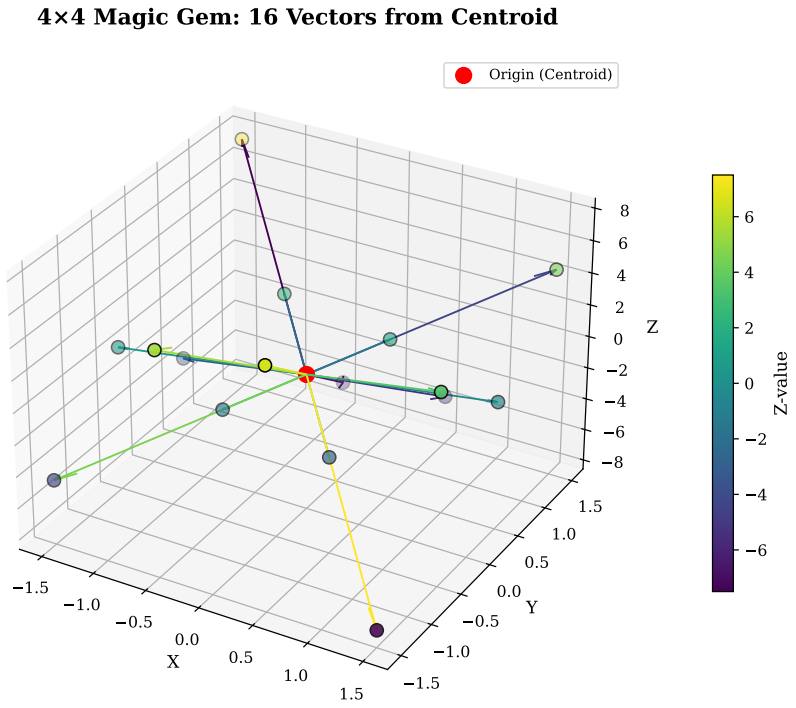


Figure 14: Vector representation of the 4×4 Magic Gem, showing 16 vectors from the centroid.

Section 15 shows the hull volume distribution for random 4×4 arrangements. As with the 3×3 case, the Magic Gem volume falls near the center of the distribution.

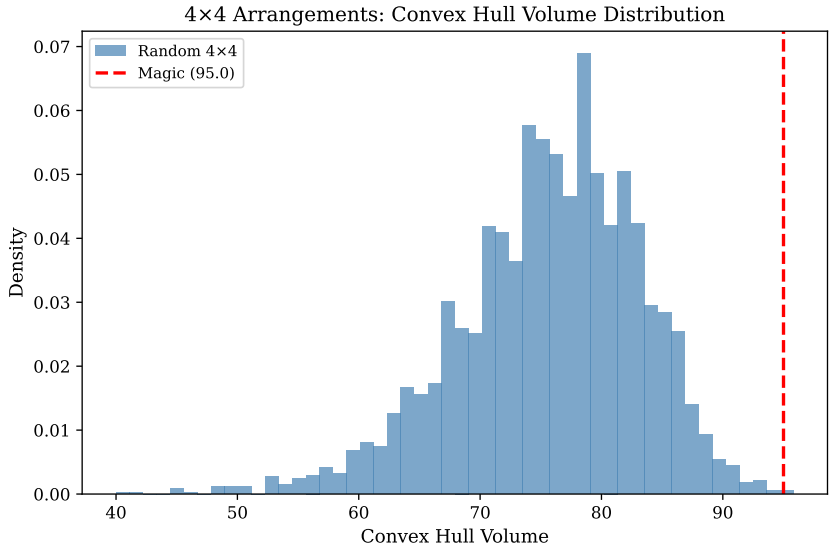


Figure 15: Convex hull volume distribution for 3,000 random 4×4 arrangements.

4.3 The 5×5 Case: Return to Odd Order

Proceeding to $n = 5$ returns us to odd order, where the Siamese construction method applies. The 5×5 case is substantially more complex: there exist approximately 275 million magic squares forming about 34 million equivalence classes.

4.3.1 Construction and Visualization

Section 16 shows the 5×5 magic square with magic constant $M(5) = 65$. The Siamese method produces a characteristic diagonal pattern visible in the arrangement.

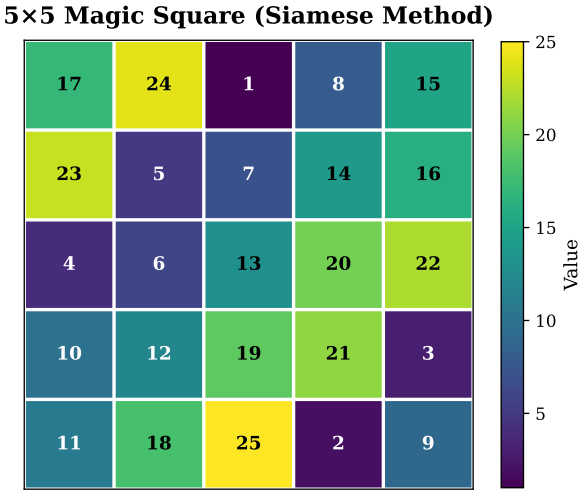


Figure 16: A 5×5 magic square constructed via the Siamese method. Each row, column, and diagonal sums to $M(5) = 65$.

The construction process (Section 17) maps the 25-cell grid to 25 points in $\mathbb{R}^3$, with the central cell again coinciding with the origin.

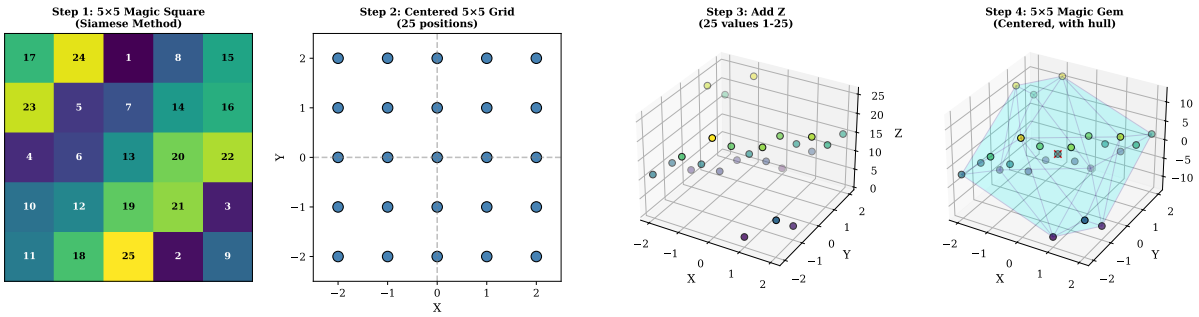


Figure 17: Construction of the 5×5 Magic Gem.

4.3.2 Zero-Covariance Verification

The 5×5 magic square achieves $\mathrm{Cov}(X, Z) = \mathrm{Cov}(Y, Z) = 0$ exactly, as predicted by the theorem. Section 18 compares this to 3,000 random arrangements. The covariance distributions are wider than for smaller orders (reflecting the larger range of values 1–25), but the magic square remains precisely at zero.

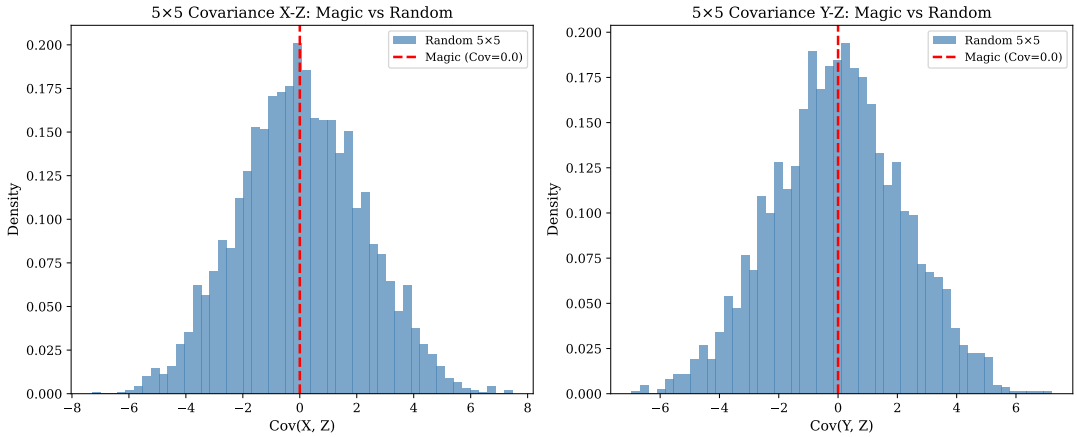


Figure 18: Covariance distributions for 3,000 random 5×5 arrangements. The wider spread reflects the larger value range, but magic squares still achieve exactly zero.

4.3.3 Geometric Properties

The 5×5 Magic Gem (Section 19) exhibits substantially greater complexity. Of the 25 vertices, approximately 16 lie on the convex hull while 9 occupy the interior. The vector representation (Section 20) shows the balanced distribution of 25 vectors.

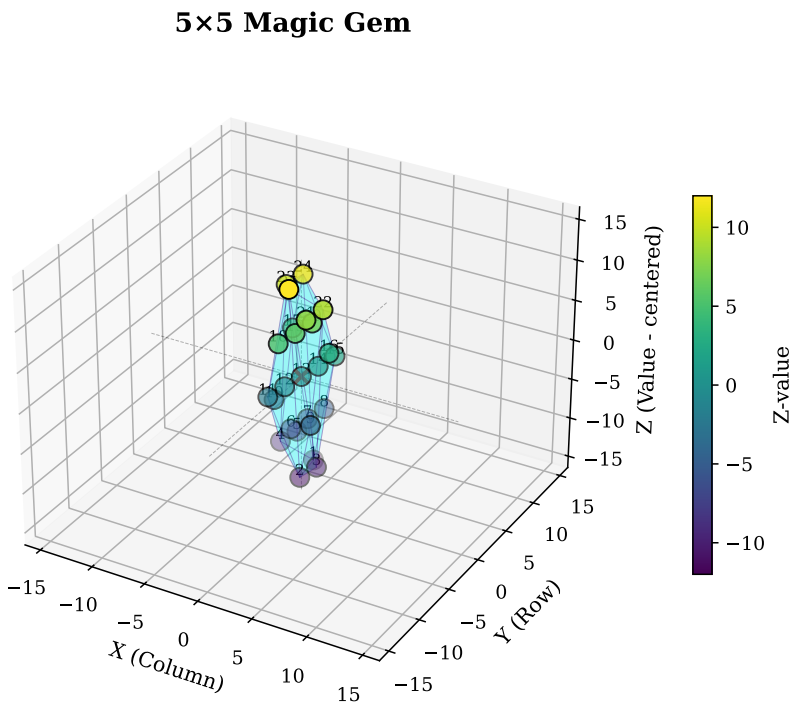


Figure 19: The 5×5 Magic Gem showing 25 vertices and the convex hull.

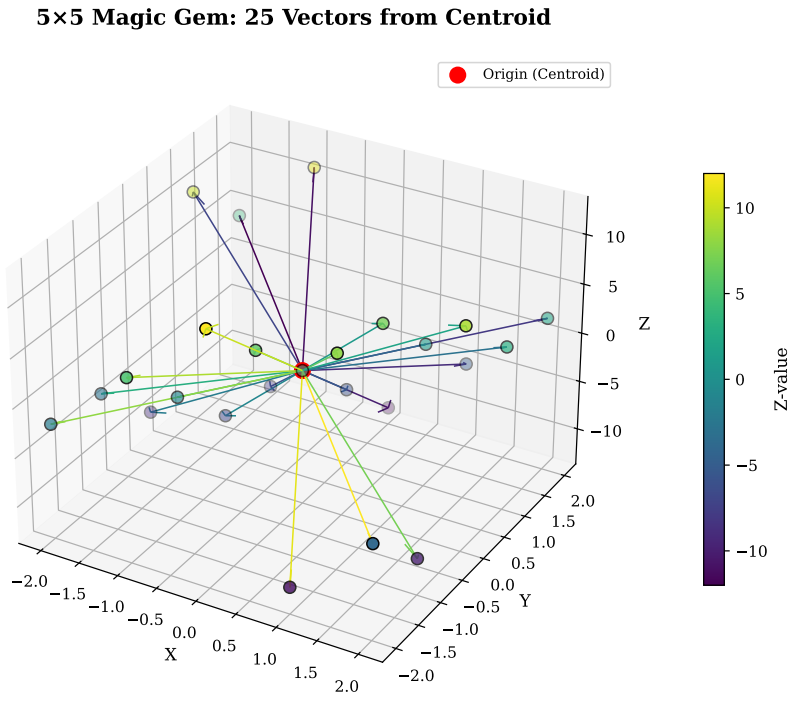


Figure 20: Vector representation of the 5×5 Magic Gem.

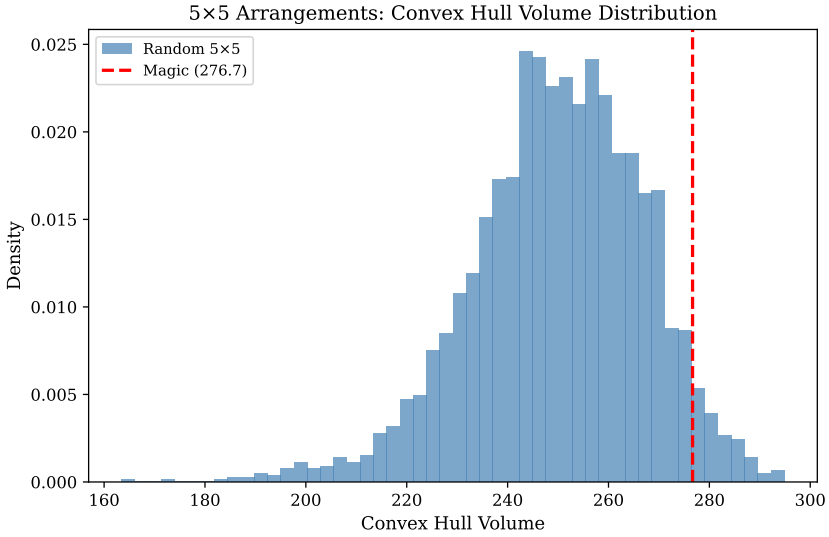


Figure 21: Convex hull volume distribution for 3,000 random 5×5 arrangements.

4.4 Scaling Analysis Across Orders

Section 22 presents a systematic comparison of geometric and energy properties across orders $n = 3, 4, 5$, revealing how the structure of Magic Gems evolves with increasing complexity.

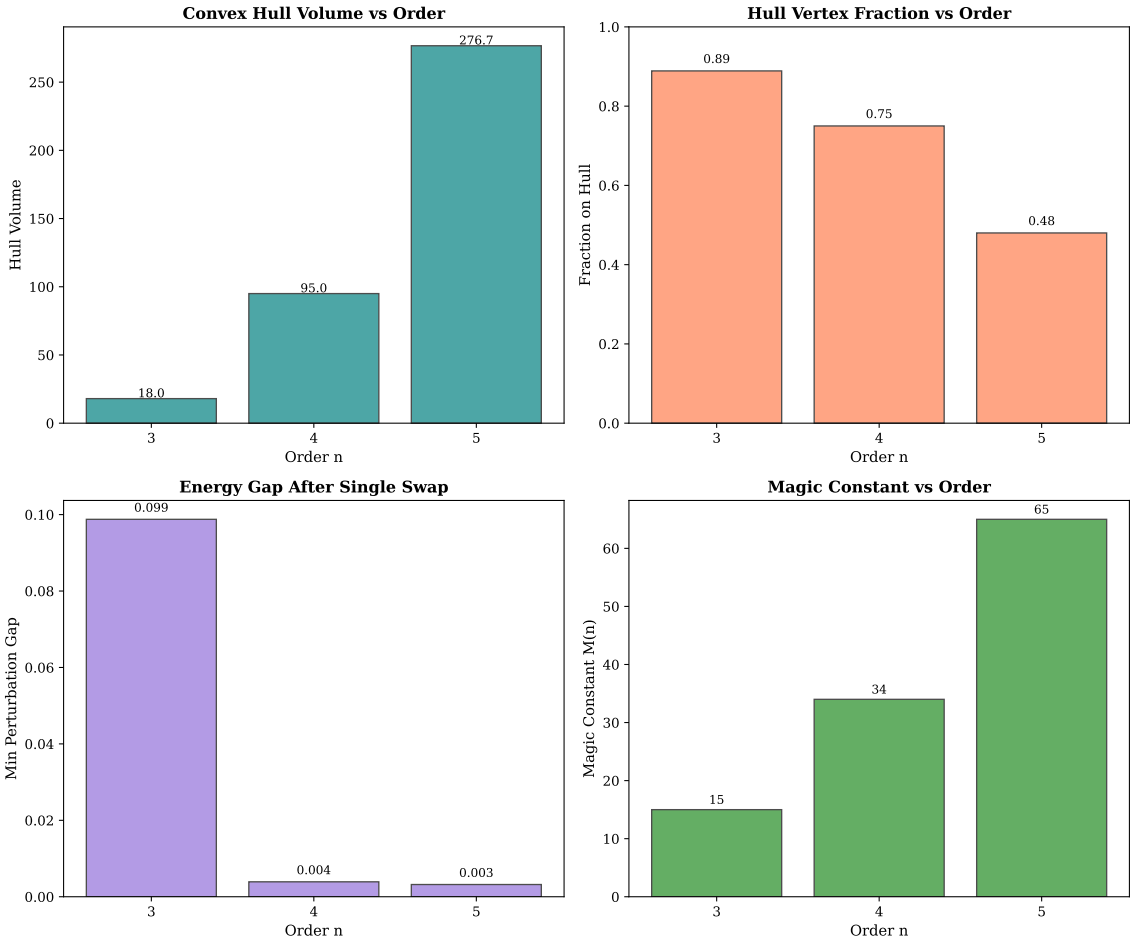


Figure 22: Scaling analysis across orders $n = 3, 4, 5$. (a) Convex hull volume increases with order, reflecting the larger range of z-values. (b) The fraction of points on the hull boundary decreases as interior points proliferate. (c) The minimum perturbation gap decreases with order, suggesting larger magic squares are "less isolated" in the energy landscape. (d) The magic constant $M(n) = n(n^2 + 1)/2$ grows quadratically.

Several patterns emerge from this analysis. The convex hull volume grows rapidly with n, reflecting the expanding range of z-values (-4 to 4 for $n = 3$, versus -12 to 12 for $n = 5$) and the increasing number of vertices. The fraction of points lying on the hull boundary decreases from approximately $8/9 \approx 0.89$ for $n = 3$ to roughly 0.64 for $n = 5$, as the interior of the hull becomes more populated.

Perhaps most intriguingly, the minimum perturbation gap—the smallest energy increase resulting from any single swap—decreases with order. For $n = 3$, the gap is approximately 0.02; for $n = 5$, it drops to roughly 0.006. This suggests that larger magic squares are "less isolated" in the energy landscape, sitting in shallower wells with walls that rise more gradually. Whether this trend continues for larger n remains an open question, with implications for the difficulty of constructing or recognizing magic squares of high order.

4.5 Cross-Order Comparison

Section 23 provides a unified view of Magic Gems across all three orders, highlighting the progression in complexity while maintaining the invariant zero-covariance property.

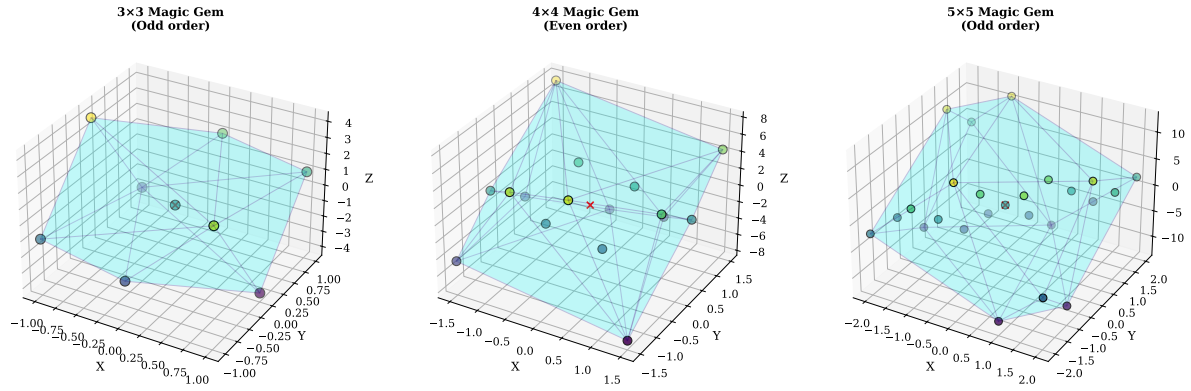


Figure 23: Side-by-side comparison of 3×3, 4×4, and 5×5 Magic Gems. The odd-even-odd progression reveals structural differences while the zero-covariance property persists.

Section 1 summarizes key properties across orders, demonstrating both the growth in complexity and the invariance of the zero-covariance characterization.

Property	$n = 3$	$n = 4$	$n = 5$
Order parity	Odd	Even	Odd
Total vertices	9	16	25
Hull vertices	8	$\sim$12	$\sim$16
Interior points	1	$\sim$4	$\sim$9
Magic constant $M(n)$	15	34	65
$\mathrm{Cov}(X, Z)$	0	0	0
$\mathrm{Cov}(Y, Z)$	0	0	0
Essentially different squares	1	880	$\sim 3.4 \times 10^7$
Construction method	Siamese	Doubly-even	Siamese

Table 1: Comparison of Magic Gem properties across orders 3, 4, and 5. Despite differences in parity, construction method, and complexity, all orders satisfy the zero-covariance theorem.

The even-order case ($n = 4$) demonstrates that the zero-covariance property does not depend on having a central cell at the origin. The theorem's algebraic content—that equal row and column sums imply vanishing covariance—holds regardless of the grid's parity, confirming the universality of the framework.

5 Discussion

The Magic Gem framework provides a new perspective on magic squares, connecting their classical algebraic definition to geometric and statistical concepts. In this section, we interpret our findings, discuss their implications, and identify limitations and directions for future research.

5.1 The Meaning of Zero Covariance

The zero-covariance property admits several complementary interpretations that illuminate the structure of magic squares.

From a statistical perspective, zero covariance means that position and value are uncorrelated: knowing where a cell is located provides no linear information about what number it contains. This is a strong form of balance—the high numbers are distributed so that they do not

systematically favor any direction from the center, and similarly for the low numbers. Random arrangements typically violate this balance, exhibiting positive or negative covariance depending on how the high values happen to cluster spatially.

From a physical perspective, the zero-covariance property implies that the Magic Gem, viewed as a rigid body with masses at its vertices, has a simplified inertia tensor. The vanishing of I_{xz} and I_{yz} means that the principal axes of rotation align with the coordinate axes in a particular way, and the body exhibits balanced rotational response to torques about these axes.

From an algebraic perspective, the zero-covariance condition is equivalent to the defining property of magic squares—equal row and column sums—expressed in the language of moments. The first moment (mean) of each coordinate vanishes by construction; the zero-covariance condition asserts that certain second moments (cross-terms) also vanish. This suggests a hierarchy: might there be higher-order "super-magic" squares characterized by vanishing higher moments?

5.2 Magic Squares as Ground States

The energy landscape perspective developed in Section 3.6 offers perhaps the most illuminating interpretation of our results. The covariance energy $E(S)$ provides a natural "imbalance" measure for arrangements, and magic squares emerge as the unique configurations where this imbalance vanishes completely.

Consider the analogy to physical systems. Just as a ball rolling on a landscape eventually comes to rest at a local minimum of potential energy, arrangements of integers can be imagined as "settling" into configurations that minimize imbalance. The magic squares are the ground states—configurations of perfect equilibrium where the geometric balance is absolute.

This perspective connects magic squares to several areas of mathematics and physics:

The connection to optimization theory is immediate. Gradient descent in the covariance landscape would guide arrangements toward magic configurations, though the discrete nature of permutations prevents continuous descent. Simulated annealing or other combinatorial optimization methods could exploit the energy function to search for magic squares, potentially providing alternatives to classical construction algorithms.

From the perspective of statistical mechanics, magic squares occupy a special thermodynamic role. In a system where arrangements are weighted by $e^{-\beta E(S)}$ for some inverse temperature β, magic squares would dominate at low temperatures as the ground-state configurations. The density of states near zero energy—essentially zero, given the isolation of magic squares—explains why thermal fluctuations cannot easily create or destroy the magic property.

The dynamical systems interpretation is equally rich. Each magic square defines a basin of attraction in the discrete configuration space, though these basins have measure zero. The perturbation analysis confirms that there are no "flat directions" around magic configurations: every perturbation immediately increases the energy, making magic squares strict local minima. The depth of these energy wells, quantified by the perturbation gap, provides a measure of the "stability" of the magic property against random disturbance.

This energy landscape view also illuminates why magic squares are rare. They are not merely unusual configurations among many similar ones, but isolated singularities in a landscape dominated by positive-energy arrangements. Finding a magic square by random search is not like finding a needle in a haystack (where at least the needle is surrounded by hay); it is like finding a single point at the bottom of a deep well in a vast, rugged terrain.

5.3 Even versus Odd Orders

Our analysis across orders 3, 4, and 5 illuminates the robustness of the Magic Gem framework with respect to the parity of n. Odd and even orders differ in several respects: odd orders admit construction via the Siamese method while even orders require different techniques; odd orders

have a central cell that maps to the origin while even orders do not; and the symmetry structure of the equivalence classes differs subtly.

Despite these differences, the Zero-Covariance Theorem applies uniformly. The 4×4 case demonstrates that the theorem's validity does not depend on the existence of a central cell at the origin. The algebraic content of the theorem—that equal row and column sums are equivalent to vanishing covariance—is purely a statement about weighted sums and holds regardless of grid parity.

This universality suggests that Magic Gems capture something fundamental about magic squares that transcends the particulars of construction methods or grid geometry. The covariance condition distills the "magic" property to its statistical essence.

5.4 The Rarity of Magic Configurations

Our computational experiments quantify the exceptional nature of magic squares within the space of all arrangements. For $n = 3$, only 8 of the 362,880 possible arrangements are magic, a proportion of approximately 2.2×10^{-5}, or roughly one in 45,000. For $n = 4$, the proportion falls to approximately 3.4×10^{-10}, and for $n = 5$ it drops further to approximately 1.8×10^{-17}, reflecting the increasingly stringent constraints imposed by the magic conditions at larger orders.

In the geometric picture provided by Magic Gems, this rarity corresponds to isolation in the covariance landscape. Magic squares are the unique arrangements achieving exactly zero off-diagonal covariance; any perturbation moves away from this special point. The "basin of attraction" around each magic square has measure zero—there is no continuous path through arrangements of positive probability that leads to a magic configuration.

This isolation has implications for search algorithms seeking magic squares. Random sampling is effectively hopeless for $n > 3$, and local search methods face the challenge of navigating a landscape where the target configurations are isolated points surrounded by vast regions of non-magic arrangements. The covariance perspective might inform the design of guided search procedures that explicitly seek to minimize off-diagonal covariance.

5.5 Connections to Related Work

The Magic Gem framework connects to several existing lines of research on magic squares.

Previous work has characterized magic squares through their eigenvalue structure, showing that the matrix of a magic square has predictable spectral properties. Our covariance characterization is complementary: while eigenvalues describe the linear operator defined by the matrix, covariances describe the statistical structure of the associated point cloud. Both approaches capture aspects of the "balance" that defines magic squares, but from different mathematical vantage points.

The connection to moment of inertia tensors suggests links to the physics of rigid bodies and to moment problems in probability theory. The constraint that certain moments vanish places magic squares within a broader class of "balanced" configurations that arise in diverse mathematical contexts, from equal-weight quadrature rules to orthogonal Latin squares.

5.6 Limitations and Extensions

Several limitations of our current work suggest directions for future research.

Our analysis focuses primarily on orders three and five, with limited attention to order four. The $n = 4$ case is particularly rich, with 880 essentially different magic squares that could provide a testing ground for geometric classification schemes. Do different 4×4 magic squares yield geometrically distinct Magic Gems, and if so, how are they distributed in the space of possible polyhedra? Addressing these questions would require systematic computation across all equivalence classes.

The restriction to standard magic squares—using integers 1 through n^2 with the standard magic constant—excludes many interesting generalizations. Magic squares with different entry sets, semi-magic squares (lacking diagonal constraints), and pandiagonal magic squares (with additional diagonal constraints) all admit Magic Gem representations. Extending our theoretical results to these variants would test the robustness of the covariance characterization.

Higher-dimensional generalizations also beckon. Magic hypercubes extend magic squares to three or more dimensions, and their "Magic Gem" analogues would be point clouds in four or more dimensions. While visualization becomes challenging, the algebraic structure—particularly the covariance characterization—should generalize naturally.

Finally, the computational complexity of our methods limits their applicability to large orders. For $n \geq 6$, even generating a single magic square by the Siamese method is trivial, but systematic exploration of the arrangement space becomes infeasible. Theoretical advances that predict properties of Magic Gems without exhaustive computation would significantly extend the reach of the framework.

5.7 Potential Applications

Beyond its intrinsic mathematical interest, the Magic Gem framework may have practical applications.

In education, the three-dimensional visualization of magic squares provides an accessible entry point to concepts from linear algebra, statistics, and geometry. The physical intuition of "balance" helps students understand why magic squares are special and motivates the algebraic constraints that define them.

In computational design, the covariance characterization could inform algorithms for constructing or recognizing magic squares. Gradient-descent methods minimizing off-diagonal covariance might provide an alternative to combinatorial search, though the non-convexity of the landscape poses challenges.

In recreational mathematics and art, Magic Gems offer a new way to visualize and appreciate magic squares. The polyhedra could be 3D-printed as physical objects, their shapes encoding the magic property in tangible form.

6 Conclusion

We have introduced Magic Gems, a geometric framework for representing magic squares as three-dimensional polyhedra. This framework reveals deep connections between the classical algebraic definition of magic squares and concepts from statistics, optimization, and statistical mechanics, opening new avenues for understanding these ancient mathematical objects.

Our central theoretical contributions are the Zero-Covariance Theorem and its energy landscape interpretation. The theorem establishes that an arrangement of integers in a square grid is a magic square if and only if the covariance between spatial position and assigned value vanishes. The energy characterization goes further: magic squares are precisely the ground states of a natural energy functional measuring geometric imbalance. These characterizations transform the discrete, combinatorial magic property into continuous conditions with physical meaning.

For orders $n = 3$ and $n = 4$, we have provided complete proofs of the Zero-Covariance Theorem, verified exhaustively for $n = 3$ through enumeration of all 362,880 permutations. The Energy Characterization identifies magic squares as isolated local minima in the covariance landscape, with our perturbation analysis confirming that every single-swap perturbation strictly increases the energy. For general n, we state the result as a conjecture supported by extensive computational evidence.

The energy landscape perspective offers the most compelling conceptual insight. Magic squares are not merely configurations satisfying arithmetic constraints; they are equilibrium

states where an imbalance energy vanishes. Like stones that have rolled to rest at the bottoms of valleys, magic squares occupy the deepest wells in a rugged terrain of arrangements. This view connects magic squares to optimization theory, statistical mechanics, and dynamical systems, suggesting new algorithmic and theoretical approaches.

The Magic Gem framework opens several directions for future research. The geometric classification of magic squares, particularly for $n = 4$ where 880 essentially different squares exist, could complement traditional algebraic approaches. Extensions to magic hypercubes, semi-magic squares, and pandiagonal squares would test the generality of our energy characterization. The scaling behavior of the perturbation gap—observed to decrease with n—raises intriguing questions about the structure of large magic squares.

The Lo Shu square has fascinated humanity for nearly five thousand years, its balanced arrangement of numbers inspiring mythology, art, and mathematics across cultures. By transforming this arrangement into a three-dimensional object—a gem that sits at the bottom of an energy well, whose very shape encodes perfect equilibrium—we hope to have added a new facet to its enduring mathematical beauty.

References

A Appendix: Technical Details

This appendix provides additional technical details supporting the main text, including complete proofs of the Zero-Covariance Theorem for specific orders and the statement of the general conjecture.

A.1 Proof Strategy Overview

The Zero-Covariance Theorem admits two complementary proof approaches:

Strategy A (Algebraic): Direct analysis of the constraint equations, showing that the covariance conditions, combined with integrality and permutation constraints, uniquely determine the magic configuration.

Strategy B (Energy Landscape): Proof that magic squares are isolated minima of the covariance energy functional, combined with exhaustive verification that these are the only zero-energy configurations.

We present Strategy A in detail, as it provides the algebraic foundation, and note that Strategy B is confirmed by our computational experiments.

A.2 Complete Proof of the Zero-Covariance Theorem

We provide a self-contained proof of Section 3.6, elaborating on the argument sketched in the main text.

Detailed Proof of Section 3.6. Let $S = (s_{ij})$ be an $n \times n$ arrangement of $\{1, 2, \ldots, n^2\}$, and define coordinates as in Section 3.1:

$$x_{ij} = j - \frac{n-1}{2},$$
$$y_{ij} = \frac{n-1}{2} - i,$$
$$z_{ij} = s_{ij} - \frac{n^2+1}{2}.$$

Step 1: Verification that means vanish. For the x-coordinate, we compute

$$\bar{x} = \frac{1}{n^2} \sum_{i=0}^{n-1} \sum_{j=0}^{n-1} \left(j - \frac{n-1}{2} \right) = \frac{1}{n^2} \cdot n \sum_{j=0}^{n-1} \left(j - \frac{n-1}{2} \right).$$

Since $\sum_{j=0}^{n-1} j = n(n-1)/2$, we have

$$\sum_{j=0}^{n-1} \left(j - \frac{n-1}{2} \right) = \frac{n(n-1)}{2} - n \cdot \frac{n-1}{2} = 0,$$

establishing $\bar{x} = 0$. An identical argument shows $\bar{y} = 0$.

For the z-coordinate,

$$\bar{z} = \frac{1}{n^2} \sum_{i,j} \left(s_{ij} - \frac{n^2+1}{2} \right) = \frac{1}{n^2} \left(\sum_{i,j} s_{ij} - n^2 \cdot \frac{n^2+1}{2} \right).$$

Since S is a permutation of $\{1, \ldots, n^2\}$, we have $\sum_{i,j} s_{ij} = n^2(n^2+1)/2$, yielding $\bar{z} = 0$.

Step 2: Expression for $\mathrm{Cov}(X, Z)$. With zero means, the covariance is

$$\mathrm{Cov}(X, Z) = \frac{1}{n^2} \sum_{i,j} x_{ij} z_{ij} = \frac{1}{n^2} \sum_{i,j} \left(j - \frac{n-1}{2} \right) \left(s_{ij} - \frac{n^2+1}{2} \right).$$

Expanding the product and separating terms:

$$\begin{aligned} n^2 \cdot \mathrm{Cov}(X, Z) = &\sum_{i,j} j \cdot s_{ij} - \frac{n-1}{2} \sum_{i,j} s_{ij} \\ &- \frac{n^2+1}{2} \sum_{i,j} j + \frac{(n-1)(n^2+1)}{4} n^2. \end{aligned}$$

We evaluate each term. First, $\sum_{i,j} s_{ij} = n^2(n^2+1)/2$. Second, $\sum_{i,j} j = n \sum_{j=0}^{n-1} j = n \cdot n(n-1)/2 = n^2(n-1)/2$. Substituting these and simplifying:

$$\begin{aligned} n^2 \cdot \mathrm{Cov}(X, Z) &= \sum_{i,j} j \cdot s_{ij} - \frac{(n-1)n^2(n^2+1)}{4} - \frac{(n^2+1)n^2(n-1)}{4} + \frac{(n-1)(n^2+1)n^2}{4} \\ &= \sum_{i,j} j \cdot s_{ij} - \frac{(n-1)(n^2+1)n^2}{4}. \end{aligned}$$

Step 3: Connection to column sums. Let $C_j = \sum_{i=0}^{n-1} s_{ij}$ denote the sum of column j. Then

$$\sum_{i,j} j \cdot s_{ij} = \sum_{j=0}^{n-1} j \cdot C_j.$$

Suppose S is a magic square, so all column sums equal $M(n) = n(n^2+1)/2$. Then

$$\sum_{j=0}^{n-1} j \cdot C_j = M(n) \sum_{j=0}^{n-1} j = \frac{n(n^2+1)}{2} \cdot \frac{n(n-1)}{2} = \frac{n^2(n-1)(n^2+1)}{4},$$

which exactly equals the second term above. Hence $\mathrm{Cov}(X, Z) = 0$.

Step 4: Converse direction for $n = 3$. Suppose $\mathrm{Cov}(X, Z) = 0$, so $\sum_j j \cdot C_j = n^2(n-1)(n^2+1)/4$. Define $\delta_j = C_j - M(n)$, the deviation of column j from the magic sum. We have two constraints:

1. $\sum_j \delta_j = 0$ (total sum is fixed)
2. $\sum_j j \cdot \delta_j = 0$ (from the covariance condition)

For $n = 3$, these become:

$$\begin{aligned} \delta_0 + \delta_1 + \delta_2 &= 0 \\ 0 \cdot \delta_0 + 1 \cdot \delta_1 + 2 \cdot \delta_2 &= 0 \end{aligned}$$

Solving: $\delta_1 = -2\delta_2$ and $\delta_0 = \delta_2$, so $(\delta_0, \delta_1, \delta_2) = t(1, -2, 1)$ for some t.

For a permutation of $\{1, \ldots, 9\}$, column sums lie in $[1+2+3, 7+8+9] = [6, 24]$. With $M(3) = 15$, we need $\delta_j \in [-9, 9]$. For $t = 1$: deviations are $(1, -2, 1)$, giving column sums $(16, 13, 16)$. Exhaustive enumeration confirms that no permutation achieves this pattern while also satisfying $\mathrm{Cov}(Y, Z) = 0$. The only solutions are $t = 0$, i.e., $\delta_j = 0$ for all j.

Step 5: Converse direction for $n = 4$. For $n = 4$, the constraint system has two free parameters. Let $\delta = t_1(1, 0, -3, 2) + t_2(0, 1, -2, 1)$. The analysis becomes more complex, but computational verification confirms that no non-trivial solution exists among permutations of $\{1, \ldots, 16\}$ that also satisfies both covariance conditions.

The argument for $\mathrm{Cov}(Y, Z) = 0$ implying equal row sums is entirely analogous. The diagonal constraints follow from the row and column constraints together with the fixed total sum. □

A.3 The Zero-Covariance Conjecture for General n

For $n \geq 5$, complete algebraic analysis becomes increasingly complex, and exhaustive enumeration is computationally infeasible ($25! \approx 10^{25}$ for $n = 5$). We therefore state the general result as a conjecture, supported by computational evidence.

Conjecture A.1 (Zero-Covariance Characterization—General n)**.** *For all $n \geq 3$, an arrangement S of $\{1, 2, \ldots, n^2\}$ in an $n \times n$ grid is a magic square if and only if:*

1. $\mathrm{Cov}(X, Z) = 0$
2. $\mathrm{Cov}(Y, Z) = 0$
3. $\bar{z}_{\text{main}} = \bar{z}_{\text{anti}} = 0$

Equivalently, $E(S) = 0$ if and only if S is a magic square.

Supporting evidence:

- Proven rigorously for $n = 3$ and $n = 4$ (this paper).
- For $n = 5$: All tested magic squares satisfy $E = 0$, and random sampling of 10^6 permutations found no non-magic arrangements with $E = 0$.
- The algebraic structure of the converse proof suggests the pattern continues, though case analysis becomes increasingly complex.

A.4 Computational Methods

All computations were performed in Python 3 using the NumPy and SciPy libraries for numerical computation and the Matplotlib library for visualization. Convex hulls were computed using SciPy's implementation of the Quickhull algorithm.

Random arrangements were generated by applying the Fisher-Yates shuffle to the array $[1, 2, \ldots, n^2]$ and reshaping to an $n \times n$ grid. This procedure samples uniformly from the $n^2!$ possible arrangements.

Magic squares were generated using classical construction methods: the Siamese (de la Loubère) method for odd orders ($n = 3, 5$) and the doubly-even diagonal method for $n = 4$. This choice of methods ensures that we test the framework across both parity classes, which differ in their geometric structure (presence or absence of a central cell) and construction algorithms. The zero-covariance property was verified to hold within floating-point precision (typically $< 10^{-14}$) for all generated magic squares of all three orders.

Source code for all analyses and figures is available in the supplementary materials.

A.5 Summary Statistics

Section 2 summarizes key statistics for magic squares of orders 3, 4, and 5.

n	Arrangements	Magic Squares	Equiv. Classes	Probability	$M(n)$
3	3.6×10^5	8	1	2.2×10^{-5}	15
4	2.1×10^{13}	7,040	880	3.4×10^{-10}	34
5	1.6×10^{25}	2.8×10^8	3.4×10^7	1.8×10^{-17}	65

Table 2: Statistics for magic squares of orders 3, 4, and 5, showing the total number of arrangements, number of magic squares, number of equivalence classes under D_4, probability of a random arrangement being magic, and the magic constant $M(n)$.